

From myths to language: examining the renaming of Kerala

The Union Government's recent approval of the proposal to rename Kerala as Keralam prompts a re-examination of the term's historicity, including its founding legend, the context of the United Kerala Movement, and arguments for the linguistic purity of 'Keralam'

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Representational image

The all-party support for changing the name of Kerala to Keralam and the Union Government's recent approval of the proposal raises questions about the historicity of the term Kerala. The historical difference between the terms is ambiguous at best. From a linguistic perspective, both Kerala and Keralam refer to a place/land. Hermann Gundert's Malayalam dictionary (1872) mentions both Kerala and Keralam while defining the term "keram" (coconut tree). One common definition of both terms is also "the land of coconut trees." Gundert takes a traditional view of Keralam as the land that lies between Gokarnam and Kanyakumari and mentions the legendary text "Keralolpatti" (The Origin of Kerala). The founding legend of Kerala is associated with Sage Parasurama (an incarnation of Visnu) who slew 21 generations of Kshatriyas and flung the blood-strained axe to the ocean, carving out a strip of coastal land called Kerala or Keralam (according to mythology), with the above-mentioned northern and southern boundaries. The history of the origins of Kerala has attracted historical scrutiny even as it is hard to determine its historical veracity. It is likely that at least some portions of the text are of latter-day origins and a response to the European

ascendance on the Malabar coast. The historicity of the text is less important than how it has been received and what place it occupies in the historical, temporal, and spatial imagination of the Malayalis.

The entanglement of myth and legend with history is not specific to Keralolpatti or any such legendary texts. What is important, however, are words and terms that encapsulate Malayalis' interaction with history and legends of Kerala. Could one say that the word "Keralam" has more historicity and cultural essence than the term "Kerala?" If yes, where do we trace that historicity and essence from? Is it going to be another set of texts or myths or legends that some consider to be more authentic and true representation of the history and culture of the region?

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